



Age restrictions for Facebook's registration

Due to FTC regulation changes, we had to implement changes on the Facebook registration flow that required people to be at least 13 years old when signing up.

Facebook’s registration flow

Previously, people were able to enter any birthday and proceed. This urgently had to be changed to meet new FTC regulation in 3 weeks.

12:49

81

<

Join Facebook



Create an account to connect with friends, family and communities of people who share your interests.

Get started

Find my account

12:49

81

<

What's your name?

Enter the name you use in real life.

First name

Last name

Next

QWERTYUIOP

ASDFGHJKL

↑ZXCVBNM⌫

123space⌵

9:38

98

<

What's your birthday?

Choose your date of birth. You can always make this private later. [Why do I need to provide my birthday?](#)

Birthday (0 year old)

February 10, 2025

Next

September52020

October62021

November72022

December82023

January92024

February102025

March112026

April122027

12:49

80

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What's your gender?

You can change who sees your gender on your profile later.

Female

Male

More options

Select More options to choose another gender or if you'd rather not say.

Next

I already have an account

12:49

80

<

What's your mobile number?

Enter the mobile number where you can be contacted. No one will see this on your profile.

Mobile number

You may receive WhatsApp and SMS notifications from us. [Learn more](#)

Next

Sign up with email

12ABCDEF

4GHI5JKL6MNO

7PQRS8TUV9WXYZ

+*#0⌫

Challenges

Introduce stricter rules on age requirements

Work with the FTC (and other regulatory bodies) to ensure our registration flows adhered to a minimum age of 13 in order to make a Facebook account.

Mitigate extra friction from new rules

While the new changes were for a good cause, we knew these changes would introduce higher friction than the existing experience which currently let people quickly skip past the date of birth screen.

Goals

What does success look like?

- Minimize negative impact on core growth metrics
- Ensure new changes wouldn't introduce any friction

My involvement

As the lead Product Designer, I worked with Product Owners, Data Scientist, Engineers and Researchers to frame design goals, synthesize research learnings, design experiments and present in leadership forums.

Understand questions

1

Why don't we have an age limit today?

One of Facebook's biggest growth markets is India, specifically, communities with lower digital literacy rates. Having simple validation/guardrails can introduce significantly higher friction.

2

What's the impact of adding an age limit?

I worked with data scientist to design and run boundary tests to understand top-line metric impact of basic age validation. This resulted in significant negative impact to WAP@14.

3

What is the right problem?

While the mission critical priority was adhering to FTC regulation, we also wanted to address the poor comprehension for the age screen itself for lower digital literacy markets (India).

4

What does winning look like?

Preventing negative top-line growth metric impact while also reducing screen drop-off rate.

Key insights

Some rural areas in India couldn't recall their birthday and often didn't have birth certificates.

The registration was a grueling process for our emerging market demographic and could sometimes take up to 45 minutes to complete.

Design principles

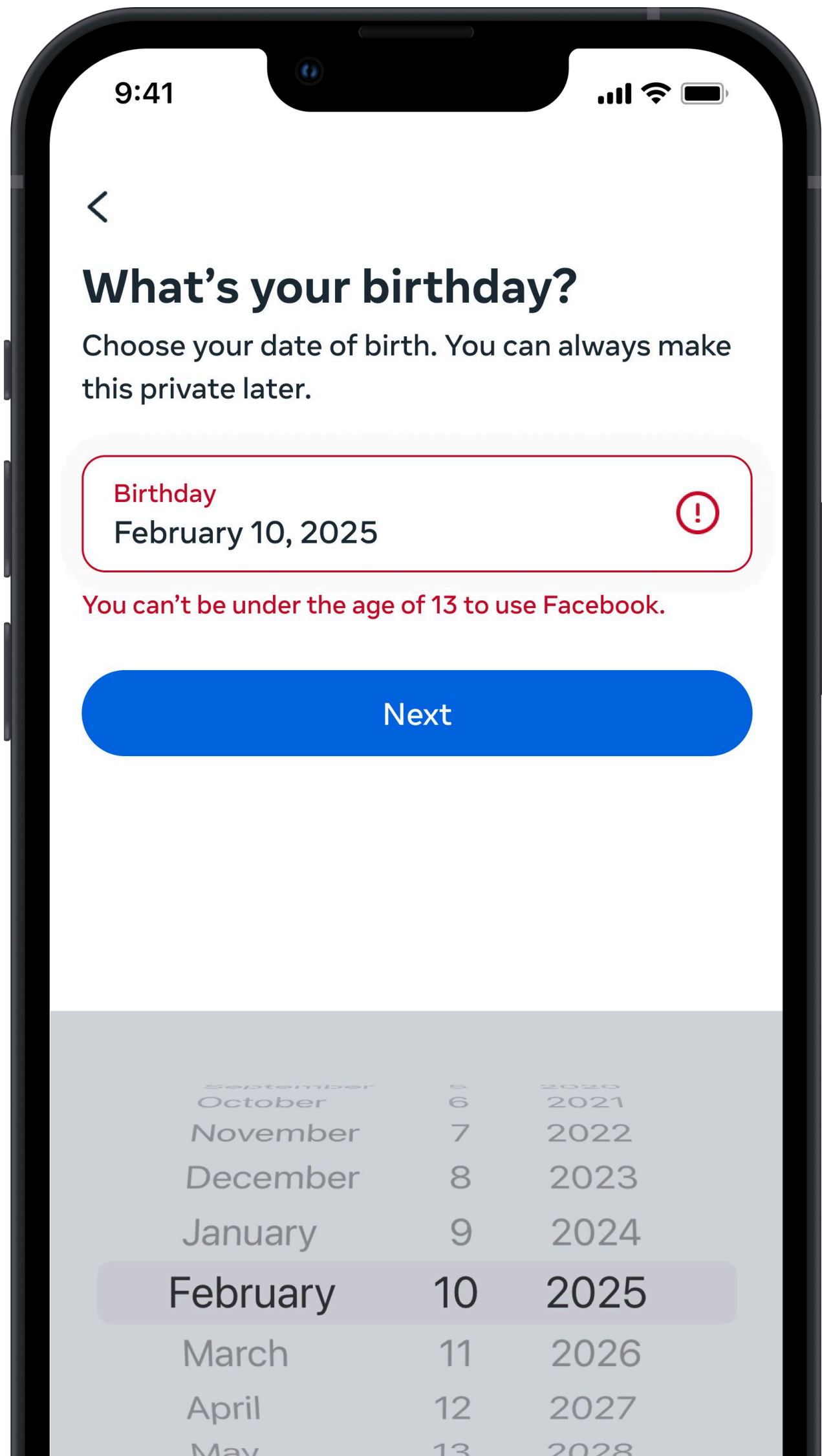
Simple. Make the design simple enough to prevent further alienating developing countries.

Transparent. Improve comprehension of what the age screen is asking.

Actionable. Provide actionable paths through this page instead of roadblocks.

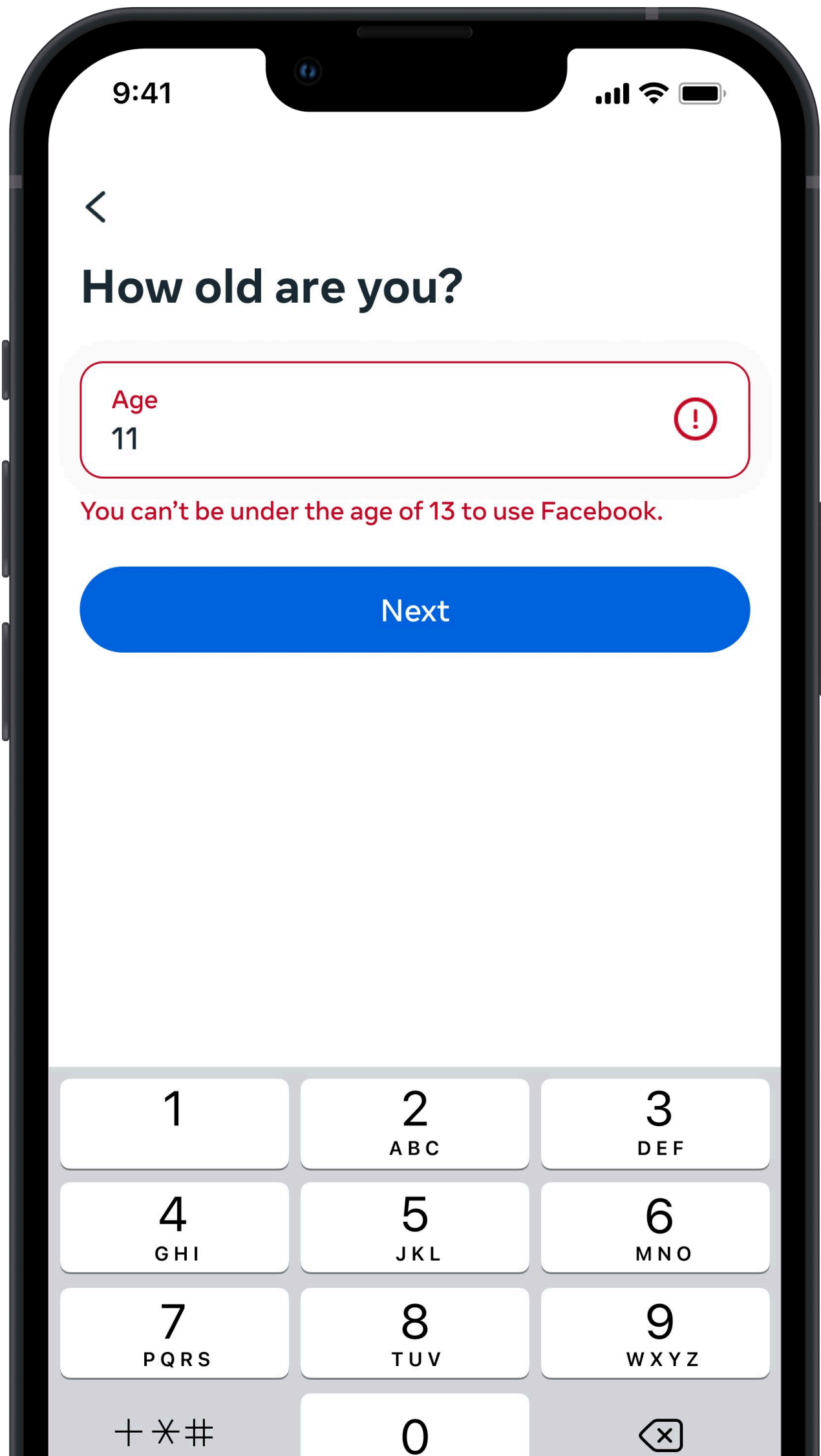
Option 1 - date picker

Here, we explored basic inline validation to explain why they can't proceed to the next page due to the age restriction.



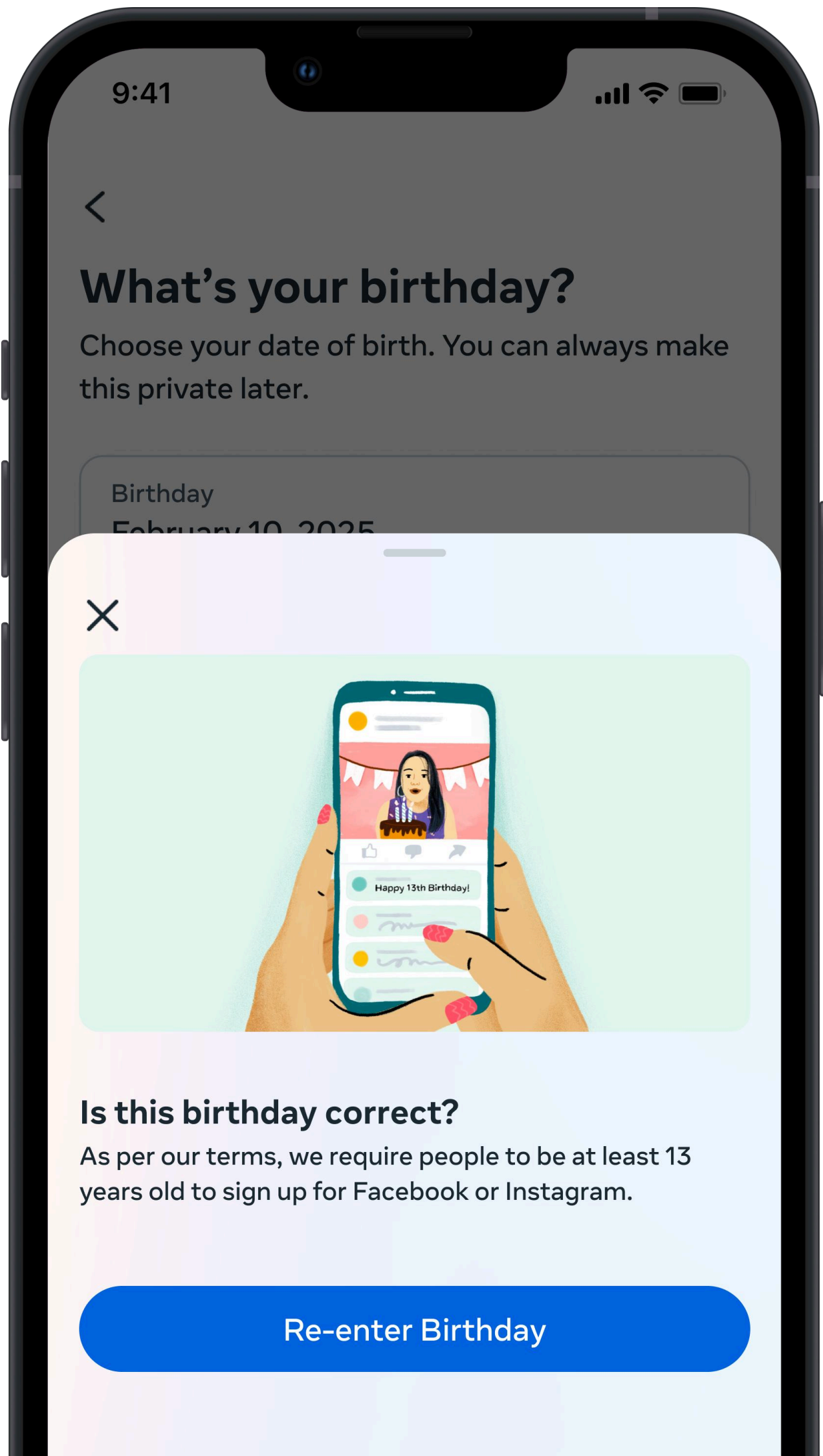
Option 2 - number selector

This version explored entering a numerical value for age instead of a traditional date picker.



Option 3 - helper link

Upon multiple failed attempts, we explored prompting a helper sheet to provide additional context in a more direct way.





Testing the designs in India

User testing & contextual inquiries

Given most of our registration traffic is from India, we traveled there with prototypes in-hand ready to test. Over multiple days we put these prototypes in front of users to gather early feedback, as well as conducting several contextual inquiries from people we had met on the street.

Option 1 - date picker

Here, we explored basic inline validation to explain why they can't proceed to the next page due to the age restriction.

9:41

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What's your birthday?

Choose your date of birth. You can always make this private later.

Birthday
February 10, 2025

You can't be under the age of 13 to use Facebook.

Next

October	6	2021
November	7	2022
December	8	2023
January	9	2024
February	10	2025
March	11	2026
April	12	2027
May	13	2028

✓ Option 2 - number selector (winner)

This screen had a higher completion rate among our testers. Although there were still some concerns around the error messaging being perceived as too "harsh".

9:41

<

How old are you?

Age
11

You can't be under the age of 13 to use Facebook.

Next

1	2 ABC	3 DEF
4 GHI	5 JKL	6 MNO
7 PQRS	8 TUV	9 WXYZ
+ * #	0	< x

Option 3 - helper link

Upon multiple failed attempts, we explored prompting a helper sheet to provide additional context in a more direct way.

9:41

<

What's your birthday?

Choose your date of birth. You can always make this private later.

Birthday
February 10, 2025

Is this birthday correct?

As per our terms, we require people to be at least 13 years old to sign up for Facebook or Instagram.

Re-enter Birthday

Audio cues

Visually softer validation

We restyled error messages to come across in a more accessible manner.

9:41

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How old are you? 

Age
11

You need to be 13 years or older to join Facebook

Next

Use date of birth

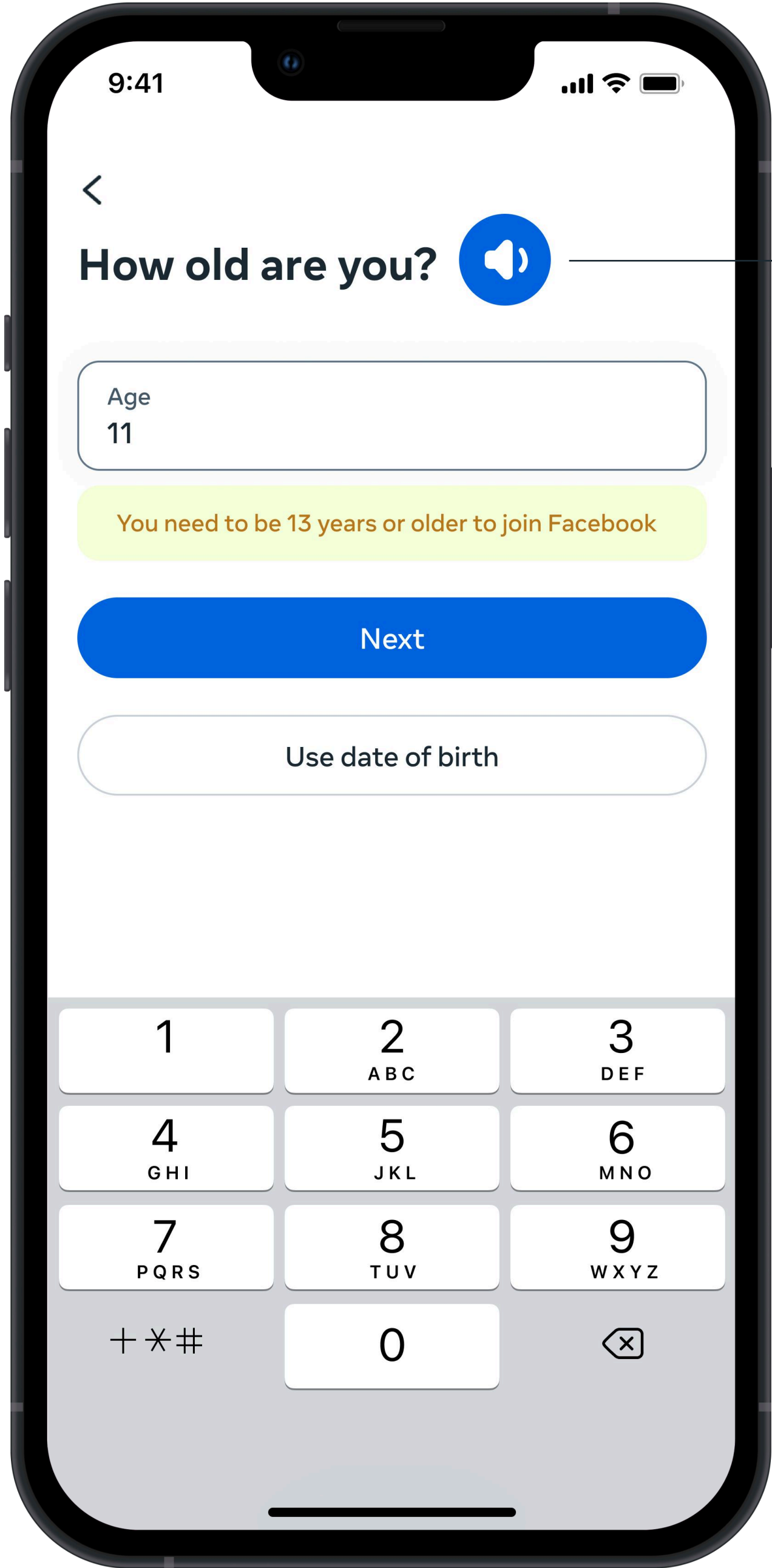
Iterating on an additional concept to improve comprehension

On-top of general reading literacy being low in our demographic, there was also at least 40+ distinct dialects of Hindi which collectively was a significant driver of comprehension issues. What if we had clearer audio cues that contextually played the right dialect?

NEXT ITERATION

Refining the concept

While we were happy with the simpler direction of the updated designs, we ran into several issues that the privacy and growth leadership team had pointed out. People coming back on Facebook to look at birthday posts was one of the biggest re-engagement drivers for the app, meaning specificity around birth date was paramount. The lack of a specific birth date also left us in a legally grey area.



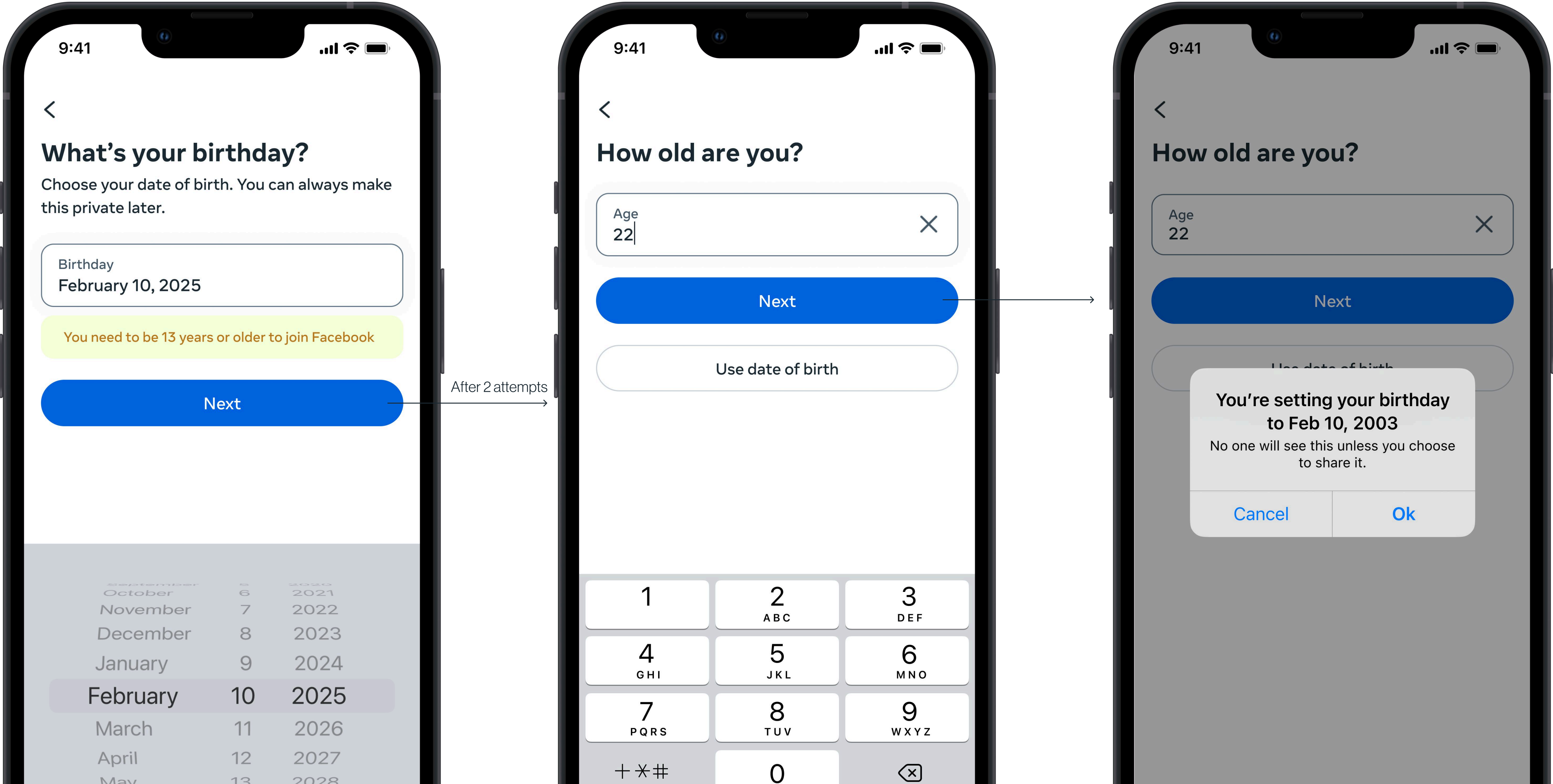
Didn't ship

Audio cues (India only)

To address the literacy gaps in rural parts of India, we conceptualized audio cues to help better explain what's being asked. Due to the complexity of this change, it was deemed out of scope.

Testing & shipping the hybrid age picker/input version

Our final version aimed to balance accurate birthday data with ease of use. If people struggled to enter their specific birthday, they could fall back on an easier route via our age input.



Translating the web experience

< > ↺ ☆ ⚙ □ 🌐 ⋮

<

 Meta

Get started on Facebook

Create an account to connect with friends, family and communities of people who share your interests.

Name

Thomas

Putt

Age ⓘ [Use date of birth](#)

14

Gender ⓘ

Male

Mobile number or email address

thomasputt222@gmail.com

You may receive notifications from us. [Learn why we ask for your contact information](#)

Password

.....

9:41

<

How old are you?

Age
22

Next

Use date of birth

1
2
3
4
5
6
ABC
DEF
GHI
JKL
MNO

Shipped

Product impact

- Prevented negative growth impact to top-line metrics
- Met FTC regulation constraints under tight deadline
- Produced higher accuracy of peoples age (India only)
- Design was scaled and eventually shipped to Instagram

Detailed metrics confidential due to NDA.

CLOSING THOUGHTS

Retrospective

- Getting the newsfeed team involved earlier in the process would have been beneficial
- Tiny details can have huge impact at scale.
- Duplicating some work/projects is hard to avoid in larger organizations
- Your own digital literacy can sometimes bias your solutions



Thank you

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